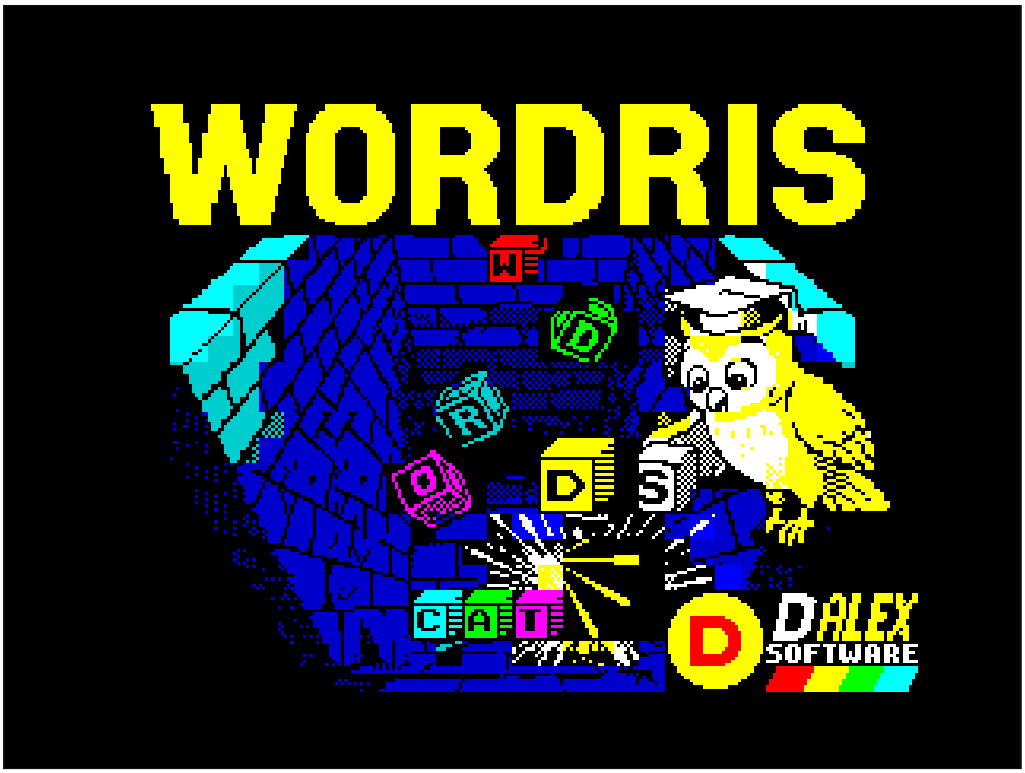
WORDRIS

BUDGET TAPE

PUBLISHER	PRICE	MACHINE	CONTROLS
Dalex Software	£1.99	SPECTRUM 128K	Keys

Letters, not lumps. Dalex's latest drops one capital letter at a time into a narrow blue well, five columns wide and ten deep, and you steer each one left or right before it lands. Line up a three- or four-letter word across or down and it flashes, scores and vanishes, and whatever was sitting on top tumbles down, sometimes spelling another word for a cascade bonus. Coloured squares round the edges triple a letter, double a letter or double the whole word, and every thirty letters cleared the pace picks up. It's a single load that takes about two minutes twenty, but there's a smashing loading picture of lettered cubes tumbling down a brick shaft, with a wise old owl looking on, to keep you company while you wait.



▲ *Cubes tumble down the shaft while the owl looks on. Time for a cuppa while it loads.*

REVIEWED BY

Kev Driscoll, Mandy Pike, Stan Hollis



▲ *NOTE goes down the side for 32 points. Kev made a note of it, loudly.*

KEV DRISCOLL

"Now this is my kind of word game: no sitting about with a dictionary, just O and P, a quick jab of SPACE and the letter slams to the floor. It moves the instant you touch the keys, and by level eleven the letters are coming down fast enough to make you sweat. Dropping NOTE down the side over a double-word square for 32 points had me whooping round the office. Mandy moans about the dead letters, and fair enough, a Q parked at the bottom is a right pain, but digging round it is half the fun. At £1.99 this is a cracking cheapie, and I kept going back for just one more go. KD"

KD

KEV SAYS **72%**

MANDY PIKE

"It's fair, I'll give it that. Every word I made was taken, the rules and the letter values are spelt out on the title pages, and the sum under each word shows exactly where your points came from. My gripe is the letters themselves. Q, J, X and Z hardly ever make a word, so they sit in the well like dead blocks and the stack slowly fills with them, which feels like bad luck rather than skill. And the rules page sells cascades as the big twist, but in normal play they hardly ever happen: I got plenty of single words and very few chains. Clever, tidy and a touch unkind. MP"

MP MANDY SAYS **68%**



▲ *Cascade! APE drops into place for six more. Monkey business, but rare monkey business.*



▲ *Game over at 17 points, but it's a new high score. Stan says it still counts.*

STAN HOLLIS

"I've seen plenty of falling-block games and this one at least looks the part: chunky lettered blocks, bold colours and not a whiff of colour clash or flicker. On the 128 there's a title tune and a separate tune in play, with spot effects for every lock and every word, and M and E switch them off when you've had enough. But level twelve looks exactly like level one: same well, same colours, same squares, just quicker. And who put a three-line jumble of numbers and letters on the credits page? No player wants to read that. Decent budget fare, nothing more. SH"

SH STAN SAYS **62%**

VERDICT

A neat little spell-binder for ten minutes at a time; the dead letters and samey levels stop it being a corker, but it's worth £1.99 of anyone's pocket money.

THE LOWDOWN

CONTROL KEYS	O/P left and right, A soft drop, SPACE hard drop, H pause, R restart, M music, E effects
USE OF COLOUR	Bright letters in their own squares, colour-coded bonus squares, and no clash at all
GRAPHICS	Neat, chunky letters in a plain blue well, and a lovely loading picture
SOUND	A title tune and an in-game tune on the 128, spot effects for every word
SKILL LEVELS	One, and it speeds up every thirty letters
SCREENS	One well, five wide and ten deep, and it never changes
GENERAL RATING	A clever word-dropper, dragged down by dead letters and samey levels

THE RATINGS

PRESENTATION	72%
GRAPHICS	70%
SOUND	66%
PLAYABILITY	70%
ADDICTIVE QUALITIES	62%

OVERALL **67%**